JJG Vocals

channel strip

User manual

VERSION 1.1.2

A complete vocal channel in one plug-in: preamp, tape, EQ, compression, de-essing and a built-in enhancer, in signal order.



The panel as it opens. Six modules in signal order, one main knob each, and a plate at the top of every module that picks the circuit voicing.

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JJG Vocals is a vocal chain built the way a mixer reaches for hardware: a preamp color first, then tape, then the tone and dynamics, with a de-esser last so nothing you boost brings sibilance back. Every stage has one main knob and a plate at the top of its module that picks the circuit voicing. The names on the plates (511, 73, TG, 60s, 37, 800, 76, 2A, 6A, 80s, 70s and so on) are the plug-in's own shorthand for the character of each voicing.

JJG Vocals has a sound of its own, and it is on by default. Like a console channel, the vocal has been through the box even with every module switched off. That is the point of the plug-in. The BOX SOUND switch in the OUT module turns that character off, and every session and preset you already have opens exactly as it did. If a vocal wants a little less rather than none, back the Mix knob off to blend in the untouched take.

The manual runs in the same order as the panel, left to right, so a control can be found by where it sits.

Requirements

- **Mac:** macOS 13.3 or later. Universal binary: runs natively on Apple Silicon and Intel Macs, and appears in Pro Tools when Pro Tools runs under Rosetta.
- **Windows:** Windows 10 or later, 64-bit.
- **Formats:** VST3 and AAX on both platforms; Audio Unit on Mac. Pro Tools 11 and later. No iLok is needed for any of them.

Installing on Mac

1. Double-click the Pizza Bagel installer package. One installer covers every Pizza Bagel plugin. It asks for your Mac password, because plug-ins live in system folders.
2. On the **Customize** screen, tick the plugins you want, then the formats: **VST3**, **Audio Unit** and **AAX**. If you're not sure, leave all three formats ticked; each one is only used by the DAWs that support it.
3. The installer and the plug-ins are signed and notarized, so macOS opens them without any security warning.
4. **Fully quit your DAW (Cmd+Q) and start it again.** Rescanning inside a running DAW is not enough; it can keep an old copy in memory.

FORMAT	WHERE	WORKS IN
Audio Unit	`/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components`	Logic Pro, GarageBand, Live, and any AU host
VST3	`/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3`	Live, Cubase, Studio One, Reaper, and any VST3 host
AAX	`/Library/Application Support/Avid/Audio/Plug-Ins`	Pro Tools 11 and later, no iLok needed

In DAWs that sort VST3 plug-ins by category, JJG Vocals is listed under EQ.

Live: after installing, open Settings, Plug-Ins, make sure the Audio Units and VST3 system folders are switched on, then Rescan.

Installing on Windows

1. Double-click the Pizza Bagel installer. If Windows shows "Windows protected your PC", click **More info**, then **Run anyway**. The installer is safe; it just is not registered with Microsoft yet.
2. Tick the plugins you want, then the formats: **VST3** and, for Pro Tools, **AAX**.
3. **Fully quit your DAW and start it again.**

Requires Windows 10 or later, 64-bit.

In DAWs that sort VST3 plug-ins by category, JJG Vocals is listed under EQ.

FORMAT	WHERE	WORKS IN
VST3	`C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3`	Live, Cubase, Studio One, Reaper, FL Studio, Bitwig, and any VST3 host
AAX	`C:\Program Files\Common Files\Avid\Audio\Plug-Ins`	Pro Tools 11 and later, no iLok needed

The user guide is in the Start menu under Pizza Bagel Plugins. To remove the plug-in, use Settings, Apps. Keyboard shortcuts use Ctrl where the Mac uses Cmd: Ctrl-Z for undo, Shift or Ctrl while dragging for fine steps, Alt-click to reset a knob.

Activating

The first time you open the plug-in, an activation screen covers the panel and the plug-in is silent until it's activated. One purchase covers **three computers**, and there's a **28-day free trial** if you'd like to try it first: start the trial from the plug-in's page in the store, then activate the same way. No iLok is needed.

1. Click **Activate online**. Your browser opens the Pizza Bagel Plugins store; sign in with the account you bought the plug-in with (or started the trial with).
2. Back in your DAW, the screen confirms the activation within a few seconds and the panel comes alive.
3. Every instance of the plug-in on this computer, in every DAW, shares the one activation. During a trial the screen shows the days remaining.

No internet on the studio machine? Click **Activate offline**: save the request file it gives you, upload it to the store from any computer that is online, and load the response file back into the plug-in. Offline activations stay on that machine until you release them from your account.

Your license. Click the version number at the bottom right of the panel to see the license details and how many of your three computers are in use, and to **deactivate** this computer, which frees the seat for another one.

If the activation screen says this computer can't be identified, write to hello@pizzabagelplugins.com and we will sort it out. It affects a small number of Windows PCs.

Where your files live

	MAC	WINDOWS
Your presets	`~/Library/Audio/Presets/Pizza Bagel Plugins/JJG Vocals`	`Documents\Pizza Bagel Plugins\JJG Vocals\Presets`
Guest factory packs	`/Library/Audio/Presets/Pizza Bagel Plugins/JJG Vocals/Factory`	`C:\ProgramData\Pizza Bagel Plugins\JJG Vocals\Factory`
Shared panel settings	`~/Library/Application Support/Pizza Bagel Plugins`	`%APPDATA%\Pizza Bagel Plugins`

"Show in Finder" in the preset menu opens File Explorer on Windows.

Signal flow

INPUT → PREAMP → TAPE → HIGH-PASS → GATE → COMPRESSION → EQ → DE-ESSER → SALT ENHANCER → MIX → OUTPUT

EQ covers Low Mid Dip, High Mid Boost, and the Low and High shelves.

Everything after Input is on the "wet" path, blended against your untouched vocal by the **Mix** knob at the end. At 0% Mix you hear the original vocal. The box has a sound of its own that is on by default, even with every module switched off; the **BOX SOUND** switch under OUT turns it off, and **Mix** blends it. See OUT.

Quick start

1. Insert JJG Vocals on a vocal track and play the vocal.
2. Pick a preamp and a tape machine from the plates on the PRE and TAPE modules, then turn **Drive** up until the vocal thickens. Below halfway Drive stays gentle; above halfway it ramps hard.
3. Turn **Comp Amount** up until the vocal sits still. It is an input knob into a fixed threshold, exactly like the classic hardware: more knob means more compression and more color together.
4. Add presence with **High Mid Boost**, tame mud with **Low Mid Dip**, and use the two shelves for weight and air.
5. Bring **De-Ess** up until the esses sit back, then add a touch of **Salt** for air.

PRE and TAPE

PREAMP PLATE

Each one distorts in its own place and reacts to Drive in its own way, so they are four different characters rather than four amounts of the same thing.

511 is the clean one: flat from top to bottom, with its only color in the bass, where its output stage thickens as you drive it. The top end is left completely alone. Pick it when you want the vocal's tone untouched and just a little weight underneath.

73 is big and thick. It has huge headroom, so it stays clean long after the others have started to crunch, and its two transformers saturate the low end first, so driving it adds body and warmth down low while the top stays open. The everyday choice for a full, expensive-sounding vocal.

TG is tight, small and aggressive. It runs on modest rails, so it breaks up far earlier than the 73, and it clips hard rather than softly; it also rolls off below 30 Hz. Pick it for edge and attitude, or when a vocal needs to sound smaller and more forward.

60s is dark and band-limited, soft at both ends, and it gets darker the harder you push it, the way old iron and tubes do. No compression of its own. Pick it for a vintage, rounded, slightly murky vocal.

TAPE PLATE

Each machine has its own top-end reach, bass bump, grit and wobble.

37 is warm and present with vintage grit: a soft top, a pronounced low bump and a gentle squeeze that thickens as you drive it.

800 is the clean modern deck: extended highs, lots of headroom, a small bump and very little wobble. Tape's glue without obvious color.

Cheap Cassette is narrow, boxy and unstable: a low top-end ceiling that drifts as if the deck were misaligned, a big mid-bass bump, hard clipping and plenty of wobble. An effect, not a polish.

102 is the pristine mastering deck: almost no color, the widest bandwidth and the steadiest transport. The faintest touch of tape.

TAPE SPEED, WARMTH, WOW

Tape Speed (7.5 / 15 / 30) scales the machine's character: slower is darker, bumpier and less stable. **Warmth** is tape tone only: high rolloff and a low "head bump", independent of Drive. **Wow/Flutter** sets how much of the selected machine's pitch instability you get.



PRE and TAPE, with DRIVE between them

DRIVE AND AUTO GAIN

Drive pushes the preamp and tape saturation together. **Auto Gain** (under Drive, on by default) keeps your level steady as you drive. Switch it off and driving harder gets louder, dirtier, and hits the compressor harder, the way a real chain does.

COMP

COMP AMOUNT

Comp Amount is the compressor's input. At 0 the compressor is out of the path. Make-up gain is automatic, so the knob reads as compression rather than volume. The plate picks the model:

PLATE	CHARACTER
76	Fast FET limiting with grit that rises as you push it. 4:1 or 8:1, chosen with the RATIO button
2A	Gentle 3:1 optical leveling with the classic two-stage release
76 → 2A	Fast peak control first, then optical leveling
2A → 76	Optical leveling first, then the 76 at 20:1 as a safety limiter
6A	Vari-mu tube limiting, 10:1 above a soft knee, with a dual time constant

RATIO

Ratio (the round 4 / 8 button at the lower left of Comp Amount, 76 only) is the 76's ratio switch, like the buttons on the front of the hardware. **4:1** is the everyday vocal setting: it levels gently and lets go quickly, so the vocal stays lively. **8:1** is the clamp: the threshold sits a little higher, so it leaves the quiet phrases alone, then grabs the loud ones twice as hard and holds on longer before letting go. Reach for it on a vocal that jumps around, an aggressive delivery, or a doubled or stacked part that has to sit dead still. Both settings keep the level steady as you turn Comp Amount, so switching between them changes the feel, not the volume. The button only appears on the plain 76; the 76 → 2A chain always runs 4:1.



COMP, with RATIO, MIX and AUTO GAIN

MIX

Mix (the small knob at the lower right of Comp Amount) is the compressor's own parallel blend. Below 100 you hear the compressed vocal mixed with the uncompressed one, and the rest of the chain (EQ, de-esser, Salt) works on that blend. The two sides are time-aligned, so backing off Mix changes how much compression you hear and nothing else. 100 is fully compressed.

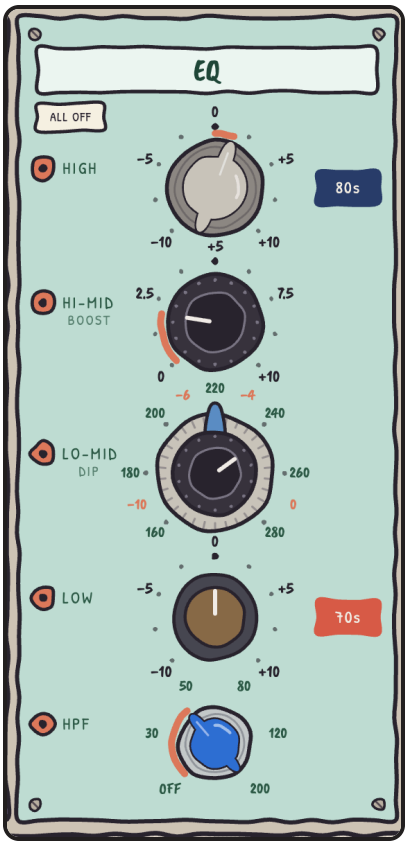
AUTO GAIN

AUTO GAIN (the pill at the foot of the module) is a measured make-up gain. The compressor's built-in make-up is a fixed prediction for a typical vocal level; Auto Gain listens instead, comparing what goes into the compressor with what comes out over a few seconds, and makes up the difference. With it on, turning Comp

Amount up changes how the vocal sits, not how loud it is, whichever model you pick and however hot the singer is. It also evens out level between sections over a few seconds, which is the nature of a measured make-up. It is off by default; switch it on per track when you want it.

EQ

Four bands plus a high-pass, each with up to 10 dB of range. Low Mid Dip only cuts.



EQ: four bands, a high-pass, and ALL OFF

LOW MID DIP AND HIGH MID BOOST

Low Mid Dip is a cut-only band for boxiness: the inner knob sets the depth, 0 down to −10 dB, and the outer ring sets where it sits, anywhere from 160 to 280 Hz (it opens at 220 Hz). The cut narrows as it deepens, so a small dip is broad and a deep one is surgical. **High Mid Boost** is a fixed 3 kHz boost whose width narrows as you push it, for presence.

EQ LOW AND EQ HIGH

EQ Low and **EQ High** are the weight and air of the voice: broad shelves with no resonance, so they never ring. The small **80s / 70s** switch beside each one picks which console it behaves like.

80s is the focused, modern voicing. Its low shelf sits at the bottom of the voice and its high shelf in the presence region, and both corners move as you turn the knob: a small boost stays polite, a big one reaches further into the mids, the way a real channel strip gets bigger as you push it. Pick it when a vocal needs to cut through a dense mix.

70s is the silky, forgiving voicing. Its shelves start lower and are shaped by a little dip just inside the boost, so a boost stays tight and warm instead of just getting bigger. The high shelf is really a broad upper lift that begins well below where esses live, so it reads as sheen and openness rather than brightness, and the low shelf adds thickness without boom. Pick it for weight and air on a voice that is already sitting right.

The console character is more than the curves. With **THD** on (the cell at the foot of the OUT module), the EQ adds the harmonics a real desk adds: a light base amount at rest, and more as the shelves are worked harder. THD off makes the EQ clean, with the same curves and nothing

added. Preamp and tape are separate and keep their own Off.

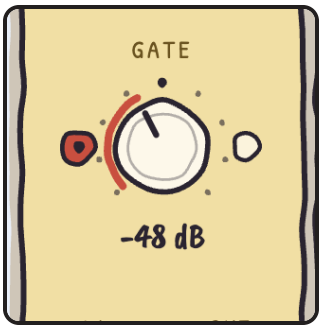
The two shelves are independent, and mixing them is the point: a 70s low for body under an 80s high for bite is the classic pairing.

HPF and ALL OFF

HPF is off at the far left, then sweeps 20 to 200 Hz with a clean 24 dB per octave slope. **ALL OFF** under the EQ plate bypasses all the bands at once.

GATE

One knob, threshold only. It is a soft downward expander rather than a hard gate: it tucks room noise and breaths down, never more than 20 dB, opens instantly, and never chatters on a wavering note. At minimum it is off.



GATE sits on the OUT module, with a lamp beside it

DS, the de-esser

One knob. The lower two thirds of its travel catch esses transparently; the top is a deliberate effect. Both circuits only act on material whose waveform actually looks like a fricative, so bright vowels and loud notes are left alone, and the moment an ess ends the reduction lets go rather than riding into the vowel that follows.

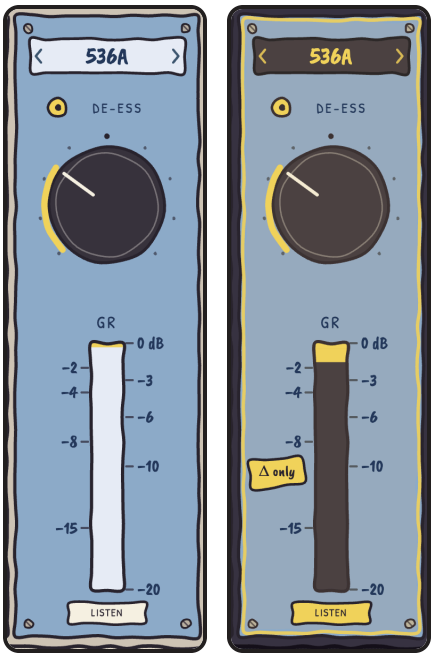
536A and 902

The plate offers two circuits, **536A** and **902**; the 902 adds an **HF ONLY / FULL BAND** switch. They are two different de-essers, not two flavors of one, and they suit different voices. If one is not catching a singer's esses cleanly, the other usually will.

536A listens for sibilance the way the classic broadcast unit did. It watches everything above about 6 kHz and judges it against the level of the voice itself, not against a fixed line: the threshold rides on the vowel that came just before the ess, so a loud chesty singer and a quiet breathy one get the same treatment. When it acts it turns the whole voice down for the length of

the ess, not just the top, which keeps the ess and the vowel around it sounding like one voice and avoids the "lisp" that filter-type de-essers can leave. It reacts to peaks, so it is fast and decisive, and the knob sets how deep it can go. Reach for it first on aggressive, close-miked or very bright vocals, on rap, and whenever the de-essing has to be strong but stay invisible.

902 works on a ratio. It compares the energy above the crossover with the energy of the whole voice and only acts when the balance tips toward sibilance. It measures average power rather than peaks, so it is smoother and more forgiving, and it reads the ess itself rather than the level around it. In **HF ONLY** (the default) it turns down only the band above the crossover and leaves the body of the voice alone, the gentler choice on soft, intimate or airy vocals, on breathy singers whose esses are quiet, and on backing vocals. **FULL BAND** ducks the whole voice like the 536A, for a harder result. The knob sets the range, the most it is allowed to take off.



DS with the 536A circuit. At right, LISTEN on: the module is framed and marked "Δ only"

Which first: 536A for a strong, bright lead that needs real taming. 902 in HF ONLY for a delicate or airy vocal, or when the 536A is grabbing more than the esses. Neither is better; they are two different detectors, and a voice that fools one rarely fools the other. LISTEN is the quickest way to compare them on a voice.

LISTEN

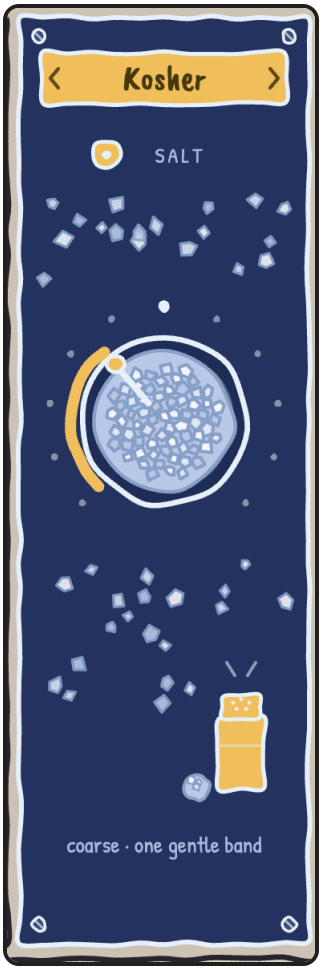
The **LISTEN** pill under the meter plays only what the de-esser is removing, so you can set the knob by ear: turn it up until the esses come through cleanly and nothing else does. While it's on the module is framed in its accent color with a "Δ only" note beside the meter, so you can't leave it on by accident; it isn't saved with presets.

SALT

The Salt enhancer built into the chain: a high-frequency lift that follows the level of the signal, so it brightens quiet passages and detail and leaves loud moments alone. That's what keeps it from getting harsh: the louder the vocal gets, the less it adds. Choose the **Kosher** or **Pink** curve on the plate and set the amount with the knob.

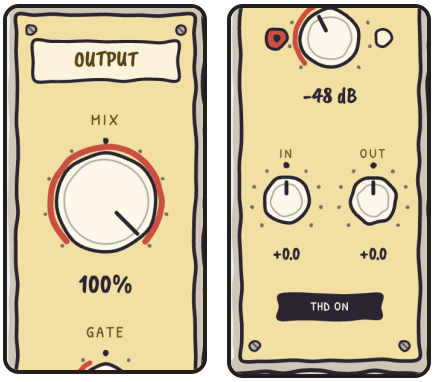
Kosher is one gentle sliding band with about 10 dB of range. It adds air a little at a time and stays polite across the whole knob. The safe default for a lead that just needs to breathe.

Pink is two staggered stages plus a skewing network, with about twice the range and a wider, more dramatic sweep. It starts a touch darker at low settings and brightens hard as you raise it. For real sparkle or cutting through a bright mix; back off if it starts to bite.



SALT, set to the Kosher curve

OUT



OUT, shown in two halves: MIX above, GATE, IN, OUT and THD below. 1.1.2 adds the BOX SOUND switch above THD

Mix is the dry/wet blend for the whole chain. It is also how you turn JJG Vocals down as a whole. The plug-in has a sound of its own that is on by default, the way a console channel does: switch every module off and the vocal has still been through the box. That is on purpose. If a vocal wants less of it, back Mix off and blend in the untouched take. At 0 you hear the original.

Box Sound is the switch for that character, above THD at the foot of the module. ON is the sound JJG Vocals has always had, and it is the default: every session and preset made with an earlier version opens with it on and sounds exactly as before. OFF makes the plug-in neutral: with every module switched off the vocal passes through untouched, and with modules on you get the modules and nothing underneath. Think of it as two plug-ins in one, the box and a clean rack. While it is off the panel wears a NEUTRAL tag and the desk takes a cooler look, so you can tell at a glance which one you are hearing. The switch is saved with presets and sessions, it is automatable, and flipping it is click-free.

The **Gate** knob lives here too, with a lamp that lights while it attenuates. **Input** and **Output** are ±24 dB trims.

THD ON / THD OFF at the foot of the module is the console harmonics switch for the EQ. On is the sound the plug-in has always had. Off keeps the EQ curves and removes the harmonics, for a vocal that wants the tone shaping without added color. It is saved with presets, and Clean Slate has it off.

Presets

FACTORY AND USER

Presets live in the top bar: arrows step through them, click the name for the list. **FACTORY** holds the presets that come with the plug-in, including folders of presets from guest mixers and producers; **USER** holds yours. **Clean Slate**, in the Justin Gammella folder, is the blank sheet: every module off, De-Ess at 0, Box Sound off and THD off, so the vocal starts untouched and you add

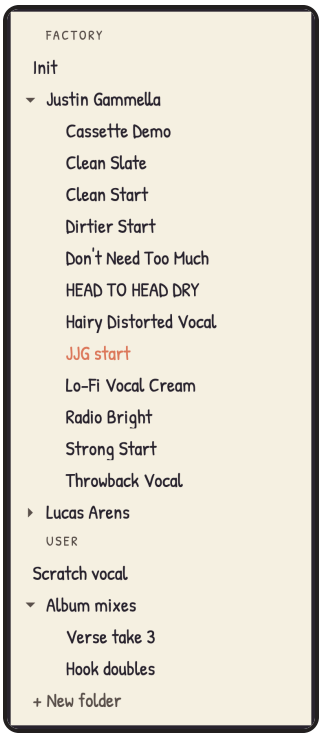
only what you reach for. 1.1.0 adds a Lucas Arens folder with eight of his presets for vocals, 808s and instruments. It installs with the plug-in. A dot before the name means you have moved off the saved state.

SAVE AND DEL

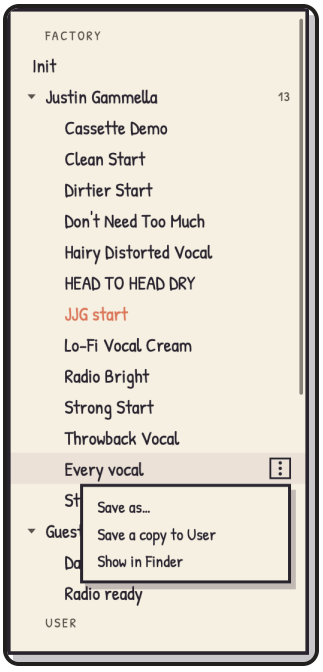
SAVE always asks for a name and a folder: keep the name to update one of your presets, or type a new one to save an alternate version beside it. Factory presets are never overwritten. **DEL** removes the loaded user preset.

ORGANIZING

Right-click any preset in the list (or hover it and click the three dots), or right-click the preset name in the top bar, for **Save, Save as, Rename, Duplicate, Move to, Delete** and **Show in Finder**. **Save** puts your current settings into that preset; **Save as** opens the name and folder box. Factory presets offer **Save as** and **Save a copy to User**. **+ New folder** at the bottom of USER makes a folder; folder names have their own dots for renaming or deleting, and clicking a folder name folds it shut. Folders are ordinary folders on disk, so you can also arrange them in Finder. Deleted presets and folders go to the Trash.



The preset list, FACTORY above USER



A factory preset's row menu

Working with the panel



The top bar: STEREO, LOW LAT, HQ, presets, SAVE, DEL, A / B, COPY, BYPASS, tooltips, undo and dark mode.

KNOBS AND TOOLTIPS

Knobs follow your hand. Drag slowly for fine moves and quickly for big ones; a full sweep is about 250 pixels at a steady pace. Hold Shift or Cmd while dragging for fine steps, five times finer. The scroll wheel nudges in small steps, and Shift or Cmd makes those finer too. **Double-click** a knob, or Option-click it, to reset it to its default; a Cmd-click without moving does the same. The tooltips say so on every knob. **Tooltips** are off to begin with. Click the **?** button in the top bar to switch them on, then hover any control for a short explanation. The **?** button always shows its own note, so you can tell whether they are on or off. **Undo** (the arrow, or Cmd-Z) steps back through your last forty changes.

A / B AND COPY

A / B holds two complete settings. The first click on the other letter copies your current state into it; **COPY** copies the current state across. Anything that differs flashes when you switch.

LOW LAT, HQ AND STEREO / MONO

Low Lat is the tracking mode: zero latency and much lower CPU, with wow/flutter and oversampling switched off. Set it before the take, not during one, and switch it off to mix. It is saved with the session, never with a preset.

HQ runs the preamp, tape and EQ color stages at 4x oversampling instead of the usual 2x. It matters when a hard-driven TG preamp or Cheap Cassette tape is pushed, where it removes the last traces of aliasing; the other voicings are already clean and sound the same either way. It costs some CPU and a fraction of a millisecond of extra latency, so it is for mixing and bouncing rather than tracking. HQ and Low Lat are exclusive: switching one on switches the other off. Like Low Lat, it is saved with the session, never with a preset.

Stereo / Mono sums the input to one channel and processes it once: lower CPU for a mono vocal, identical sound.

AUTOMATION AND MIDI

Every control is automatable in every DAW. In Pro Tools, hold control+option+command and click a control to enable automation for that parameter, as with most plug-ins; button presses and menu picks are recorded too. **MIDI learn:** right-click any knob, switch or plate, choose LEARN MIDI CC, then move a control on your MIDI controller; right-click again to clear it. Any CC on any channel works, and the hover note on a mapped control shows its CC. Mappings are saved with the session, not with presets. To get MIDI into the plug-in: in Pro Tools, set a MIDI track's output to the JJG Vocals insert; in other DAWs, route a MIDI track or your controller to the plug-in's MIDI input.

DARK MODE AND RESIZE

Dark mode (the half-moon) dims the desk. **Resize** by dragging the bottom-right corner. Window size, dark mode and the tooltip switch are shared by every JJG Vocals instance in every DAW: change one and the others follow, and new instances open the same way.

Good to know

- The plug-in reports about 7 ms of latency at 44.1 kHz in normal and HQ mode, which your DAW compensates automatically. Low Lat reports zero.
- Mono inputs on a stereo track are handled: the mono signal is mirrored to both sides.
- Your DAW always saves the exact settings with the session, preset or not.

GET IN TOUCH

Bugs, license trouble, feature ideas: use the contact form at pizzabagelplugins.com, or email hello@pizzabagelplugins.com. A real person reads every one. We are a small company, so please give us up to 3 to 5 business days to reply.

Pizza Bagel Plugins. All product names on the panels are the plug-in's own labels for its voicings and modes.